

Porteus: An alternate RAM-resident distribution

Wikipedia has a list of distributions that run from RAM. Porteus seemed appealing. It evolved from Slax, which also runs from RAM and uses a KDE desktop. Porteus offers you an option of KDE and LXDE desktops. The newly released version 2 has an XFCE-based alternative package as well. Another attraction of Porteus is that it includes the option to boot into Porteus using PXELINUX from a machine running Porteus. Version 2 is even easier, as it has an *initrd* with the network drivers included; no modification of *initrd* is needed for client machines. You may adopt the scripts to use *dhcpcd* and the Apache Web server instead, and boot into Porteus from a server running Fedora (see <http://goo.gl/BxdBG> for details), Ubuntu or any other distribution.

Porteus Linux Flavour	Boot-up Time
Porteus v2.0 KDE from local disk	35 sec
Porteus v2.0 LXDE from local disk	Under 20 sec
Porteus v2 KDE using HTTP over 1 Gigabit net connection	50 sec
Porteus v2 LXDE using HTTP over 1 Gigabit net connection	40 sec

Porteus v2 KDE using HTTP over 100 MBps net connection	70 sec
Porteus v2 LXDE using HTTP over 100 MBps net connection	55 sec

What is striking is that Porteus with an LXDE desktop boots from the local disk in half the time of Puppy Linux! Even the KDE desktop boots faster. The most likely reason would be the more recent kernel version used by Porteus. Puppy Linux uses Linux kernel 3.2 for i386, while Porteus uses kernel 3.7, and we chose the x86_64 architecture. Subtle differences in the Linux Live Kit scripts between the two versions might also make a difference.

I had not expected the network boot to add about 15 seconds to the boot time even on a Gigabit network, for distributions of the order of 200 MB. Hopefully, with the renewed active development of iPXE, you may see significant improvements. 

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